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PACKAGE ACCESSORY

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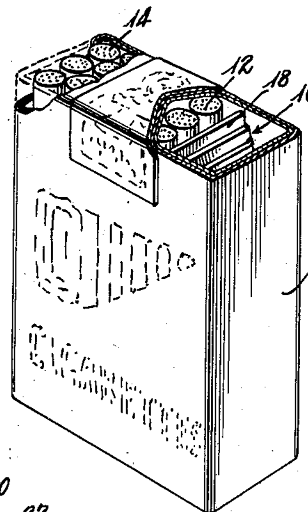


Fig. 1.

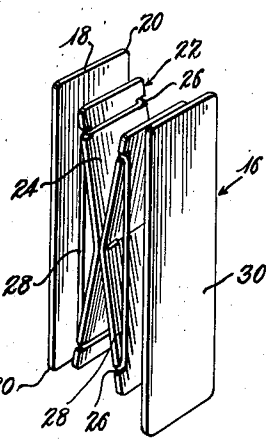


Fig. 2.

Fig. 3.

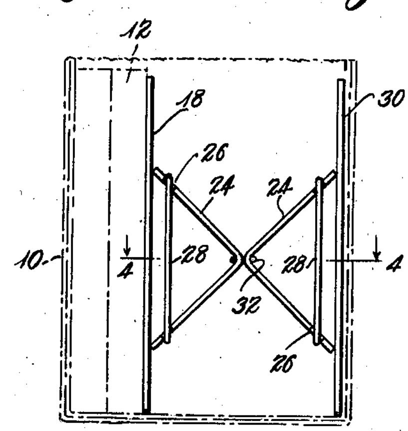


Fig. 5.

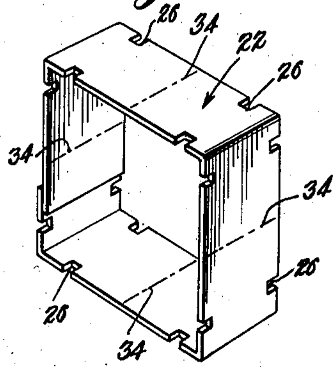


Fig. 6.

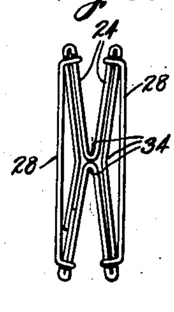
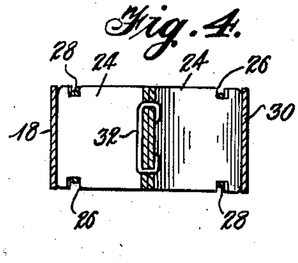


Fig. 4.



Inventors

John M. Murphy and
Thomas A. Burba Jr.

By [signature]

Attorney

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UNITED STATES PATENT OFFICE

2,185,605

PACKAGE ACCESSORY

John M. Murphy, Shamokin, and Thomas A. Burba, Jr., Paxinos, Pa.

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9 Claims. (Cl. 206—41)

This invention relates to accessories for packages of elongated articles which are removed from time to time in part only and not returned to the package. More particularly the invention relates to an accessory for a cigarette package in connection with which the invention was conceived.

Cigarettes and like articles are customarily packed in oblong packages of paper or the like, and the cigarettes are arranged therein in parallel relation to each other, usually in tiers or rows of three. It is the general practice in the trade to thus package and sell cigarettes and it is customary to form the packages of paper. It is common practice among users of cigarettes, to tear away part of one end of the package to expose the ends of several cigarettes for extracting the same one at a time by pulling the cigarette longitudinally out through the torn away part of the package. Cigarette users have experienced that after a number of cigarettes have been removed from a package, the remaining cigarettes become dislodged from their original position and lie obliquely within the package in such a manner that their withdrawal becomes difficult. Furthermore, the conventional paper package, when partially emptied, is easily crushed and becomes misshapen after a few of the cigarettes have been removed.

It is an object of this invention to provide an accessory for cigarette packages which may be either packaged with the cigarettes at the point of manufacture or which may be inserted by the purchaser. A further object is to provide an accessory which will insure ready access to the cigarettes at the open end of a package until the last cigarette has been withdrawn.

It is a further object of the invention to provide a device which will not only serve to move the cigarettes progressively toward the package opening but will also serve to maintain the package in its original shape.

It is a further object of the invention to provide a device of the class described which can be manufactured at a minimum cost so that the same may be embodied in a package of cigarettes without adding materially to the cost of the production thereof.

Other objects and advantages of the invention will become apparent as this description proceeds, having regard to the attached drawing in which like reference numerals indicate like parts throughout the several figures, and in which

Figure 1 is a perspective view of a package of cigarettes with the accessory placed therein at one side of the package, parts of the package having been broken away to show the interior thereof;

Figure 2 is a perspective view of the accessory;

Figure 3 is a side view of a cigarette package with a side wall thereof removed to show the device in operative relation with the package and its contents;

Figure 4 is a sectional view taken on line 4—4 of Figure 3;

Figure 5 is a perspective view of a modified spring mechanism forming a part of the invention; and

Figure 6 is an elevational view of the modified spring mechanism in a folded position preparatory to its insertion into a cigarette package.

The conventional cigarette package 10 is formed of various layers of relatively thin flexible paper in the usual manner. This package is adapted to contain a plurality of cigarettes 12. A cigarette smoker usually tears away a portion of the top of the package to expose the ends of several cigarettes, as at 14. It is usually a simple operation to withdraw cigarettes from a package in this maner so long as the package is substantially full. When, however, half of the contents, for example, have been exhausted, the package becomes crumpled, the cigarettes assume oblique positions within the package, and on the whole, the withdrawal of further cigarettes through the opening 14 becomes difficult.

In order to insure a continuous supply of cigarettes at the opening 14, and in order to present the cigarettes at this opening in an upright and parallel position, the accessory, generally indicated at 16, has been provided. This accessory comprises a follower 18 which is substantially as long as the cigarettes and as wide as the internal width of the package in which the same is to be used. The corners 20 of the follower 18 are preferably rounded so as to facilitate the movement of the follower from one edge of the package to the other.

This follower is inserted in the cigarette package 10 at one edge thereof and in contact with the last tier of cigarettes therein. Between the follower 18 and the wall of the package is provided a spring mechanism 22. This mechanism is composed of two arms 24 which are adapted to be folded upon themselves along a transverse line intermediate the ends thereof. The ends of the arms 24 are connected to tension means which will react to the withdrawal of cigarettes to effect the folding movement of the arms. For example, each end of each arm 24 may be provided with notches 26 through which may be passed rubber bands 28 which will tend to fold the arms 24 upon themselves. It will be understood, of course, that when the spring mechanism 22 is first inserted into the package, the arms 24 will lie back to back in parallel position and will be disposed in a plane parallel to that occupied by the follower 18. As several cigarettes are withdrawn from the package, the arms 24 will be drawn towards each other by the elastic bands 28 thus advancing the follower 18 to move cigarettes from the rear of the package toward the forward edge thereof to replace those which have been withdrawn.

Good results can be obtained by using the spring mechanism alone. When the follower 18 is omitted, the ends of one of the arms 24 will rest against the last row of cigarettes. The pressure of the arm 24 in contact with the cigarettes will operate to move them toward the open end of the package, and since the arms 24 are preferably as wide as the cigarette tier the pressure will be substantially uniform across the contents of the package. The follower 18 is, however, useful in that it serves to distribute the operating pressure along the length of the cigarettes and guards against damage to the cigarette which might otherwise result.

In order to maintain the package in its original shape, and to prevent crushing thereof, there is provided a supporting member 30 which is similar in size and construction to the follower 18. This member is generally disposed against the rear edge of the cigarette package and the spring mechanism 22 is interposed between the supporting member 30 and the follower 18. The follower 18 and the supporting member 30 together constitute a support for the package, even though substantially emptied, which lends rigidity thereto and prevents crushing of the same when carried in a user's pocket.

The arms 24 of the spring mechanism may consist of two strips of flexible material which may be joined together transversely and intermediate the length thereof, for example, by means of a staple 32. This is however, only one method of construction which may be modified. A modification thereof is illustrated in Figures 5 and 6 of the drawing, wherein the spring mechanism is generally indicated by the numeral 22 and is formed of a single piece of sheet material, the ends of which may be joined to form a four-sided figure as shown in Figure 5. This figure may then be creased or scored at the points 34 to permit folding of the same in the manner illustrated in Figure 6 of the drawing. This method of construction eliminates the use of staples or other attaching means but may be less desirable than the principal form of the mechanism because of the greater amount of material required for its construction.

Since this accessory is adapted to be packed with cigarettes at the place of manufacture, and since it is contemplated that the package together with the accessory be discarded after the cigarettes have been used, the same must be capable of construction at a very low cost so that no addition need be made to the eventual cost of cigarettes to the user. Towards this end it is contemplated that the accessory be constructed of light weight sheet stock such as cardboard of the Bristol board type, although the precise material may be determined by convenience in the manufacture.

While the invention has been disclosed in two forms and has been described in connection with cigarette packages, it is expected that various modifications in the construction thereof may be made and its use may be varied. It is, therefore, not desired to limit the use of the invention other than by the limitations imposed thereon by the subjoined claims.

What we claim is:

1. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a spring mechanism adapted to be placed in contact with said articles to advance the same toward an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of interconnected arms foldable upon themselves about a transverse line located intermediate their ends, and means interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to folded position.

2. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a follower adapted to contact the articles throughout substantially their entire length, a spring mechanism for urging said follower against said articles to advance the same toward an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of interconnected arms foldable upon themselves about a transverse line located intermediate their ends, and means interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to folded position.

3. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a support member, a follower adapted to contact the articles throughout substantially their entire length, a spring mechanism interposed between said support member and said follower for urging said follower against said articles to advance the same toward an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of interconnected arms foldable upon themselves about a transverse line located intermediate their ends, and means interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to folded position.

4. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a follower adapted to contact the articles throughout substantially their entire length, a spring mechanism for urging said follower against said articles to advance the same towards an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of arms joined to each other along a transverse line intermediate their length and being foldable upon themselves about said joint, and means interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to folded position.

5. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a support member, a follower adapted to contact the articles throughout substantially their entire length, a spring mechanism interposed between said support member and said follower for urging said follower against said articles to advance the same towards an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of arms joined to each other along a transverse line intermediate their length and being foldable upon themselves about said joint, and means interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to foldable position.

6. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a follower adapted to contact the articles throughout substantially their entire length, a spring mechanism for urging said follower against said articles to advance the same toward an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of interconnected

arms foldable upon themselves about a transverse line located intermediate their ends, an elastic band interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to folded position.

7. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a support member, a follower adapted to contact the articles throughout substantially their entire length, a spring mechanism interposed between said support member and said follower for urging said follower against said articles to advance the same toward an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of interconnected arms foldable upon themselves about a transverse line located intermediate their ends, and an elastic band interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to folded position.

8. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a follower adapted to contact the articles throughout substantially their entire length, a spring mechanism for urging said follower against said articles to advance the same towards an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of arms joined to each other along a transverse line intermediate their length and being foldable upon themselves about said joint, and an elastic band interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to folded position.

9. An accessory for packages of elongated articles comprising a support member, a follower adapted to contact the articles throughout substantially their entire length, a spring mechanism interposed between said support member and said follower for urging said follower against said articles to advance the same towards an opening in the package, said spring mechanism consisting of a pair of arms joined to each other along a transverse line intermediate their length and being foldabde upon themselves about said joint, and an elastic band interconnecting the ends of each of said arms for moving the same to foldable position.

JOHN M. MURPHY.
THOMAS A. BURBA, JR.